

Oldtimers Still Going Strong

CHICAGO (AP) — By age 36 most professional baseball players are has-beens.

But some hang on, some even cling to stardom.

Pete Rose's 67 hits, Phil Niekro's 81 strikeouts, Willie McCovey's 40 RBIs, and Luis Tiant's 2.78 ERA are among the major leagues' best this season.

Niekro and McCovey are 39. Rose is 37. Tiant says he's 37 but some think he may be over 40.

Others reach milestones. Gaylord Perry, 39, is third in career strikeouts, Tony Perez, 36, passed the 300-home run mark, and Rose climbs his way toward Stan Musial's 3,630-hit National League record.

Chicago Sun-Times baseball writer Joe Goddard asked members of baseball's Geriatric Gang how they still compete with the best while watching their hairlines recede.

Their training habits range from wheat germ to wine, from long-distance running to leaning against dugouts, from racquetball to a round of golf.

McCovey, who left his heart in San Francisco after being traded to the San Diego Padres, says returning to the Giants pumped life into his hitting.

"I didn't feel like it (the Padres) was my team," he said. "I couldn't get away from the Giants. I'd find myself looking at their box scores first and hanging around with ex-Giants wherever I was."

Diet-watching Texas Ranger shortstop Bert Campaneris, 37, won't consume anything his body won't like. The wiry wonder never touches the spirits — and drinks a glass of wine about as often as he makes an error.

Jim Kaat, the health-food loving 39-year-old Philadelphia pitcher, eats it all — wheat germ, soybeans, honey. A beer chaser doesn't hurt much either, he says.

Manny Mota and Willie Stargell psyche their way to success.

Stargell used to write down statistical goals on pieces of paper and put them in his batting helmet as reminders, but age and injuries have limited the 37-year-old Pirate's aspirations. He still relies on positive thinking.

"I've never been a negative thinker," he says. "I think I can still do the job and I intend to do it." A 500-foot homer this season made many fans believers.

Earl Meyer Vacates UTEP Coaching Post

Earl Meyer, assistant basketball coach at the University of Texas at El Paso for one year, has resigned his post, UTEP athletic director Jim Bowden said Monday.

"Earl expressed an interest in returning to high school coaching," Bowden said. "He said he had enjoyed his work here, but wanted to return to the high school level in the San Antonio area."

Prior to his position at UTEP, Meyer had coached 10 years in the San Antonio schoolboy ranks, the last seven at Burbank High School, where his teams won three district championships, two bi-district titles and one regional crown. His squads twice led the state in defensive statistics.

Bowden said he hopes to fill three coaching vacancies at UTEP before the end of June. Earlier, head baseball coach Andy Cohen and women's basketball coach Carol Amerman had announced their resignations. Last week, the athletic trainer vacancy was filled with the hiring of El Paso's Don Forrester.

Pair Of Unsets